

Constituent Record

Submitted to Philadelphia City Council — May 6, 2026 Hearing on Bill 251026

The following 210 statements were submitted by Philadelphia residents and business owners who signed the LIFT Philly petition at liftphilly.org. These are their words, unedited, explaining how the elimination of the \$100,000 BIRT exemption has affected their lives and livelihoods. Signers represent every corner of the city's independent workforce — from therapists and artists to landlords, freelancers, and community supporters — united by a shared call for relief.

44

Mental Health & Therapy

32

Arts & Creative

2

Early Intervention & Education

21

Freelance & Consulting

15

Housing & Real Estate

17

Health & Wellness

39

Small Business Owners

2

Tax Professionals

38

Supporters & Community

210

Total Signers

Mental Health & Therapy (44 signers)

I am being taxed out of my home and my business will not be able to remain in Philly—I will not be able to do the work of helping the people of Philly who I care so much about—if this tax remains in place.

— **JEANINE MARIE STEWART** *Mental Health / Psychotherapy*

I have been running my business for 16 years and the taxes are making me think I cannot have my business in Philadelphia anymore.

— **Ruth Conviser** *Mental Health Services*

I am a new clinician working as a 1099 contractor at a group practice. I am not a traditional business owner—I don't have as many deductions as most businesses. I'm also dealing with student loans, paying for my own health insurance and earning my hours towards independent licensure. I will be leaving Philly instead of opening up my own practice here as previously planned solely because of the BIRT change. It has made it impossible for me to save anything, I'm living paycheck to paycheck while trying to support others with their mental health. It's making it incredibly difficult to manage my own. I feel hopeless about the future.

— **Meg Costa** *Counseling & Therapy*

The removal of the BIRT exemption is disproportionately impacting mental health practitioners in private practice, most of whom are sole proprietors who make less than \$100k. Extrapolating from national stats, private practice therapists make up HALF of the entire mental health field in our city. Private practice psychotherapists like me offer an essential service to our city's economy. We stabilize working people, prevent crises from worsening, and keep people in their jobs and family lives. Today, about 20% of adult Americans suffer from some sort of mental illness, and recent research has shown that untreated mental illness among Americans, namely workers, cost the US economy about \$282 billion a year. But the BIRT tax exemption removal has raised the taxes on my small business by a factor of 6. BIRT has made me, and every colleague of mine in a similar position I've spoken to, seriously consider moving my small business out of the city.

— **Lillian Dunn** *Psychotherapy*

I have had my clinical psychology practice in the city of Philadelphia for 36 years. This year my BIRT tax went up by a factor of six. It is leading me to consider the longevity of my practice.

— **Dr. Karen Eselson Belding** *Clinical Psychology*

My counseling practice provides needed services to Philadelphians, including people on Medicaid. These tax changes are making it significantly harder for me to keep my practice open.

— **Patrick Grugan** *Counseling & Therapy*

I love Philadelphia and want to be able to run a successful business here.

— **Mattea LeWitt** *Counseling & Therapy*

The BIRT is making me consider relocating my business and where I live. I love Philly so much, but this makes me strongly reconsider.

— **Brittany Webb** *Mental Health Services*

I own a solo practice providing individual, couples and family therapy. I'm a single income household. I make under \$100,000 a year and have no benefits—no paid leave, vacation, workers' comp—and I have to pay my mortgage, utilities, nearly \$900 a month for health insurance, and student loans. In 2024 I made \$11k more than 2025 and had to pay around \$3,200 for NPT to the city. Now for 2025, with the new BIRT tax I had to pay almost \$5,000 between BIRT and NPT. So I made \$11k less and had to pay around \$1,800 more in Philly taxes than the previous year. Offering a grant that we can apply for that only covers business expansion costs does not help me pay my mortgage or health insurance. You are going to lose many therapists at a time where you need more mental health workers because we can't afford to live or have businesses here.

— **Lydia Bennett** *Mental Health Counseling*

I budgeted especially carefully this year in order to pay my bills in spite of unpaid maternity leave. I kept up with quarterly estimated taxes, even for the period during which I had no income. And then was hit with a devastatingly high tax bill that I did not expect or understand. This tax makes it hard to feed my family or stay in business. Please reconsider.

— **Nomi Teutsch** *Counseling & Therapy*

I want therapists to be incentivized to stay in Philadelphia and provide much needed mental health services to our communities rather than relocate to the suburbs.

— **Amy Jones Sehgal** *Counseling & Therapy*

This change drastically impacted my taxes. If not changed back, I will move my business out of the city once my lease is over.

— **Christopher Wilson** *Mental Health Services*

I am a small business owner and a parent of two young kids. Having to pay local tax that is essentially two times more than the state tax liability has put a significant burden on my family and will impact our ability to keep living and raising our children in Philadelphia. I hope that our collective concerns will be taken seriously!

— **Valeriya Spektor** *Mental Health Services*

My husband and I actually both have small businesses—his is doing SEO work for small companies. Combined, we owe over \$6k this year and will need a payment plan to pay it all, plus interest. We are getting advised to live or work outside of Philadelphia despite being here since 2016. I work in underprivileged schools and with low income children with special needs as a contractor—this type of tax will crush both of us and force us out of valuable work helping children, families, and other small businesses.

— **Aleksandra Brodskaya** *School and Private Speech Therapy Services*

I just opened my business in January 2025. If I had known about this tax, I wouldn't have opened it here in Philly. Shame on this tax bill.

— **Cassidy Flynn** *Mental Health Services*

An increase in taxes would impact my ability to sustain my practice and continue providing services.

— **Jamica Cropper-Pam** *Counseling & Therapy*

This large tax increase for the smallest businesses and gig workers isn't healthy or right. I'm facing a difficult decision to leave the city in order to sustainably continue as a sole proprietor.

— **Kasryn Kapp** *Mental Health Services*

It's ridiculous that I can't even make a living helping people when now the city wants to charge us a tax on our services.

— **Kathryn Ewers** *Counseling & Therapy*

This puts an undue burden on people who barely are making enough to pay bills as it is. It seems correct to me that once you make over \$100,000, then you start paying this tax.

— **Erika Barrington** *Mental Health Services*

I am a second career graduate student about to enter the field of mental health counseling. My partner has a small business that offers bookkeeping and tax prep services. This tax hasn't affected me yet, but it will. We have already started conversations about whether this tax, among other taxes, is enough for us to consider moving out of the city. We don't want to, but we are worried.

— **Tara Rubinstein** *Counseling & Therapy*

I am a solo business owner, already feeling the tax burden of living and working in Philly. But I love it here and it's always been important to me to invest in and work in the city where I live. This recent BIRT increase was an alarming shock to my system. I already run on pretty thin margins to be able to do the work I do and earn a living. The city and all of us as community members benefit from small businesses staying here in the city—laws like this make it exponentially less possible to do so.

— **Erin Volpe** *Counseling & Therapy*

I love working, living, and serving the people of Philadelphia and I want to continue to do so in a way where I can thrive and sustain.

— **Shara Harad-Oaks** *Mental Health Services*

As a small business owner, the new BIRT tax plus the estimated taxes, in addition to the high taxes we already pay, are unaffordable and impossible to manage.

— **Kimberly Kaplan** *Mental Health Services*

I am a single member LLC, self employed as a mental health therapist. I work with suicidal teenagers and young adults, especially from marginalized communities. My husband is disabled, so my income is what sustains my family. The BIRT should not be meant for people like me—I am not profiting; I am simply trying to make enough to live, support my husband and support my community. The BIRT has drained our savings this year.

— **Megan Stitz** *Counseling & Therapy*

BIRT taxes will ruin the city's early intervention system, which is primarily sole proprietor independent contractors.

— **Mindy J King** *Occupational Therapy, Early Intervention*

This increase is unfair and unsustainable. It amounts to taking a whole week's gross income out of my pocket. I have worked as a sole proprietor in Philadelphia for over 20 years. I could have stayed completely online after the pandemic, but returned to leasing an office in Center City because I love it, and because I felt it was better for the city for us to come back and to be a part of its cultural and financial life. Now I will have less cash to spend in other small businesses in Philadelphia. The knock-on effect of this will be really significant. Now I am considering whether it is worth my effort to stay in business in this city. Please bring Bill 251026 to a vote and do the right thing for people.

— **Laura Hawley** *Mental Health Services*

As a single person LLC I try to keep my overhead really low in order to survive. This tax really is an undue burden and becomes one of my largest expenses for the year.

— **Doren Day** *Massage Therapy*

I have had my business for 17 years now and am proud to work and live in Philly. We raise our kids here and send them to Philly public schools. As a parent and also a caregiver to an elderly mother with Alzheimer's, it is important for me to have a flexible schedule and to keep my business running in a way that allows me to maximize my time and the support I offer to my clients, while being available for my family's needs. I do this work because I care about people's mental health. Additionally, it is an essential part of my business practice that I be able to offer clients a sliding scale fee for therapy—I prioritize offering reduced fees for folks who financially cannot afford treatment. This new tax scale is a hardship to those of us who have small businesses and big family and community responsibilities.

— **Margaret Hogan** *Mental Health — Private Psychotherapy Practice*

I tried my best to run a one-person therapy business in Philadelphia. It was a struggle for 3 and a half years, but the changes to the business tax structure were the final nail in the coffin, forcing me to cut my business back to the bare minimum and take a full-time job elsewhere to make ends meet. I am all for paying my fair share of taxes. I love Philadelphia and want our city to grow and succeed. But these changes will drive small businesses to close or to move out of Philadelphia.

— **Blair Davis** *Mental Health Services*

Entrepreneurship is the soul of any municipality and the city administration should be ashamed for working against it.

— **Owen Murphy** *Mental Health Services*

I owe the city so much more this past year than my first year of business, and I have yet to hit \$100,000 in profits.

— **Brianne Scott** *Mental Health*

I've been in business for 7 years and this tax is hitting me hard at a time where cost of living and health insurance are skyrocketing. Please protect small businesses!

— **Deborah Rubin** *Mental Health Therapist*

I work really, really hard to pull together about \$80k in NEC, out of which I need to pay for continuing education and office space and electronic systems to maintain confidential client records. I need to pay for overpriced Pennie insurance. The previous exemption made it possible to survive as a solo private practice therapist.

— **Leslie Stickler** *Mental Health Services*

New business, getting out of unsustainable contracts from unethical business owners. Trying to serve the community and also be able to afford a home and maybe children one day. Taxes are already insanely high. Small businesses that are built from passionate people sharing love in the city cannot afford more taxes. It's insulting to treat community members this way.

— **Giavanna Copsetta** *Mental Health Services*

I run a small business in Philadelphia and actively choose to live and work here because it is my favorite city in the world. I have built my life and business here for 14 years and I am a graduate of Temple University. I am deeply invested in this community. Being required to pay approximately \$12,000 out of pocket for BIRT this year feels overwhelming and honestly shocking. For a small, virtual business without a brick and mortar location and 1 employee, this is an enormous and disproportionate burden. The requirement to prepay future taxes only adds more financial strain and uncertainty. This does not feel supportive of small businesses. It feels like we are being pushed out. I do not want to leave Philadelphia, but this tax is forcing me to consider it.

— **Emily Lewis** *Mental Health Services*

11 years.

— **Cynthia Closs** *Social Work*

The end of the BIRT exemption really impacted me financially due to the hefty tax bill I owed. I am not against paying my taxes in order to contribute to the city, but I am disappointed and frustrated that small business owners have to bear the brunt of this tax bill while big corporations can take advantage of loopholes to avoid giving back to the city.

— **Kyra Sjarif** *Counseling & Therapy*

I make below the poverty level as a single mother and pay a higher tax rate than Comcast.

— **Stephanie Jackson** *Massage Therapy*

I've seen some of the best people in healthcare and trades who have served their communities for years recently go out of business because of large corporations with inferior services and products—and no real ties to the local community. Small local businesses run by people who care about and live in the local communities in which they serve are the foundation of society. I'm trying to grow my new business into a sustainable therapy practice that supports the local community. Mental health and wellness is more important than ever.

— **Adam Kaluzshner** *Mental Health Services*

I've worked to build my business for the past 9 years and finally got to a place where I could afford needed medical care and maybe even take a nice vacation. I was so proud of myself and feeling hopeful about my financial future. I have no safety net—it's just me. All of that changed with this change in taxes and being squeezed on all sides economically this year. I wish Philadelphia had offered some actual support if this change was inevitable. Surely other relief could be offered.

— **Colette Grosso** *Counseling & Therapy*

To help support other small businesses also affected by this raise in the BIRT tax threshold.

— **Amanda Montemuro** *Massage Therapy*

The old tax waiver helped small businesses survive as they grow. Removing the BIRT tax waiver made it that much harder on people with modest incomes. City officials didn't fight for small businesses when challenged by Zoll Medical Corp, meanwhile big corporations constantly get tax breaks.

— **Christie Eastburn** *Mental Health Services*

I want Philadelphia to support their small businesses. I believe this bill will force more and more small businesses into the counties, hurting our city and creating less accessibility for Philadelphians. There's no reason to punish small businesses that are trying to grow because of pressure from large out of state law firms. This feels like the wealthy harming the average Philadelphian and I would hope our city government has greater loyalty to its own people than it is currently demonstrating.

— **Amy Moulton** *Mental Health Services*

I've been in business in Philadelphia for over 24 years as a sole proprietor. This current tax burden makes my private practice unsustainable. Please pass this bill so that my business and many others can continue to thrive (and pay taxes).

— **Rachel Allender** *Psychotherapy*

Arts & Creative (32 signers)

I've been paying the BIRT for years. Paying it double for the first year was a slap in the face, as it continues to be for every year I earn more than the previous year. As a sole proprietorship it's absolutely wild I should get taxed double or quadruple as much as someone paying the wage tax just because I generate my own income. All because someone with barely any standing decided to sue because other people got a tax break? Ridiculous.

— **Daniel Soham Peterse** *Theater & Performing Arts*

I'm new to the city and was so excited to move here and conduct my business here. This tax has been a huge hit to my business and making me consider moving out of the city.

— **Brianna de Moll** *Graphic Design & Visual Art*

I've run my consulting business in Philadelphia for 7 years. This year my tax accountant said I should move out of Philadelphia because it is too expensive to keep my business going here. I am still not sure how I will be able to pay the 2025 and 2026 BIRT bill; for now I am on a payment plan.

— **Selina Morales** *Videography & Film*

This is harmful to the success of hard working independent people.

— **Alyse Bernstein** *Artist*

I can't continue paying out so much in taxes for so little support.

— **Netanel Portier** *Visual Arts & Muralism*

It is extremely hard to be an independent performing artist at the best of times. An additional tax burden is an insult, considering we are at the very bottom of the payscale. Tax wealth, tax big corporations, tax second-home-owners, tax people who can spare it!

— **Larisa Mann** *Live Performance*

I've been working as a freelance writer, communications consultant, and artist and paying taxes in Philly for more than a decade. I have recently begun looking for full-time work in part due to Philadelphia's excessive taxation on freelancers, which makes self-employment simply unsustainable in this city. Despite the high taxes I pay, I've seen little progress in those taxes going towards things that matter to me—clean streets, increased funding for arts and culture, more protected bike lanes. I hope City Council will take the impact of BIRT on self-employed workers seriously. It is unfair to ask the self-employed to front this money when we already pay self-employment taxes while receiving no unemployment benefits if our work dries up, and bearing the cost of all of our own benefits.

— **Nicole Quenelle** *Communications and Arts*

I have been a freelance artist for most of my life. The wages that I make in my field are not enough to live on. Additional taxes are not at all helpful. Small businesses in Philadelphia should not have to pay additional taxes as I am sure we are all still struggling since the pandemic and affected by the adverse economy more than any large corporation.

— **Cybele Moon** *Theater & Performing Arts*

I've been working as a freelance theatre artist for 15 years. Having to pay this tax makes it significantly harder to live.

— **Cat Ramirez** *Theater & Performing Arts*

Arts workers are already underpaid and under resourced by the city, while wealthy developers, corporations, and universities benefit. Now the city is taking more of my money, but I don't get the benefits!

— **Daniel Park** *Theater & Performing Arts*

This double taxation is a burden on independent contractors like myself who are already feeling the pinch from an unsteady market. Philadelphia needs to support its small and independent businesses, not bleed them dry. Without these businesses, neighborhoods will lose their community lifelines and be at the mercy of large corporations that care about profit over people.

— **Alison Barretta** *Media and Consulting*

This is a burden on me, my family and my very small business.

— **Rachel Kotkoskie** *Graphic Design & Visual Art*

The changes to BIRT affect me and other self-employed and freelancing workers in a way that punishes us for pursuing engagement with the arts ecosystem of Philadelphia and could ultimately create an environment in which artists and creatives begin to move out of the city for more hospitable living and working conditions.

— **Joseph Ahmed** *Theater & Performing Arts*

I am an independent choreographer and dancer working between Philadelphia and Bulgaria (where I am from). Historically, Philadelphia has been one of the most important centers for the development of contemporary dance styles. Here, world-renowned artists lived and worked to hone their craft. As the city with the most theaters per capita, it is imperative to continue to support independent and freelance artists.

— **Zornitsa Stoyanova** *Dance & Movement*

We should be helping small businesses thrive instead of focusing on them to generate wealth for the city. I believe the city's strategy needs assessment and redirection.

— **Shannon Murphy** *Theater & Performing Arts*

Less taxes on small business.

— **Daniel Kaplowitz** *Music & Performance*

The BIRT tax and the requirement to pay my estimated tax for 2026 up front this year was crushing. I'm now behind on my other bills because I had to meet this obligation for the city. I didn't get a letter about the BIRT update until December of last year, and I had no idea that I would have to pay tax year 2026 up front. The roll-out of this new policy has felt punishing for indie workers.

— **Alaina Johns** *Writing & Journalism*

I just transitioned from full time work to freelance. The flexibility suits our family's needs with two children. The unexpected tax payment was an unfortunate strain on an already small amount of income to start.

— **Samantha Shaffer** *Graphic Design & Visual Art*

I have two small businesses that are difficult to make a profit from. Anything that raises my taxes makes it even harder. I'm a technology writer and a fine arts painter. My professions add flavor and style to this city.

— **Deborah Rich** *Writing & Journalism*

I'm a solo freelancer in video post-production, I gross way under \$100k per year, and I can't afford this tax increase. My mind's on covering rent and groceries. I was already paying ~30% in taxes, and this new tax is another ~10% of my income (I have to pre-pay for next year?!). This is so, so serious. There's no money left to bleed out of us.

— **Annie Huntington** *Post-Production*

It's hard enough out here for a freelancer, this is overtly burdensome to those of us who make so little already.

— **Tory Noll** *Prop Styling*

The film industry is expensive enough. Artists and filmmakers are exploited enough. Keep our resources in our pockets and your economy gets better! We will create experiences, document legacy, and reinvest in the community, creating authentic culture with this resource. Let the people decide how to spend their hard earned money.

— **Lydia R Conner** *Videography & Film*

While not the fault of city council or mayor, not enough was done to prevent the damage caused by the elimination of the BIRT exemption. My BIRT increased by over \$5,000 compared to last filing.

— **Courtland Winslow** *Graphic Design & Visual Art*

It's already hard enough to be an arts entrepreneur in Philadelphia lifting up the entire community with the work we do to tell great stories about our creatives here. Philadelphia continues to punish small business owners, who are the lifeblood of the city.

— **Heather Blakeslee** *Media*

Small businesses have it tough enough as it is.

— **Joe Lamberti** *Writing & Journalism*

My business is still growing and will not be able to sustain with the BIRT tax in addition to other state/municipal/city taxes. I have come through the city of Philadelphia for both school and college and I feel my business deserves the chance to maintain here as well. Otherwise, I will have to move it elsewhere.

— **Lailah Coleman** *Graphic Design & Visual Art*

I'm a sole proprietor of a business that barely makes enough to support my child. I'm often qualifying for aid services based on the year. I cannot afford another huge tax and to run my business. I understand that the change of this tax was posted, but it doesn't mean that small businesses could afford to prepare for it. Are large businesses being taxed at an appropriate rate or is there another way to make up this income for the city?

— **Meredith Nutting** *Videography & Film*

Philly should support small business growth. I feel like I am drowning in taxes.

— **HOPE VELOCETTE** *Interior Designer*

I'm a one-person business with minimal margins in Philadelphia for many years. The large tax increase will make it difficult for me to continue.

— **Jim Loewer** *Graphic Design & Visual Art*

Twenty years ago I explained the first-hand negative impact of BIRT on sole proprietors to members of city council while shooting a national news piece with them. All these years later, we STILL don't have a permanent fix. It's time!

— **Kaci Crooks Vecchio** *TV Production*

In the next 5 years the only businesses that will be able to thrive in Philadelphia will be corporate giants, if this tax continues the way it currently is.

— **Olivia Merida** *Lifestyle Brand*

Large corporations are getting a pass while the rest of us are struggling!

— **Sarah Browning** *Writing & Journalism*

Early Intervention & Education (2 signers)

The taxes are unfair to small business owners.

— **Quinn Bauriedel** *Education*

To support independent contractors in Philadelphia who serve children with special needs.

— **Nadine Mille** *Tutoring & Education*

Freelance & Consulting (21 signers)

This year I paid over \$5,000 for the BIRT tax. When reviewing this with my financial advisor, he immediately suggested I move out of Philadelphia. I am a sole proprietor just scraping by. I haven't gone on a real vacation in years. The BIRT tax will force me to exit the city I've invested in for 25 years if it continues. Is that really how Philly wants to get rich?

— **Meg Lemieur** *1099 / Freelance*

As a freelancer, I am hired to perform the same job during the same hours as full-time employees (because it's cheaper for the business I am hired by), except I don't get benefits or healthcare. I am not a business in the general sense of the word, I just get paid my wages on a 1099. I already pay city wage tax and self-employment tax on my income, now without the BIRT exemption my tax burden on that same income has gone up thousands of dollars. BIRT is a punishment on top of an already disadvantaged employment situation. I can't imagine how this is affecting people who are scraping by.

— **Jessie Amadio** 1099 / Freelance

I literally just started my business this year and this tax will be detrimental.

— **Rachael Ard** 1099 / Freelance

Been a sole prop. in Phila for 25 years.

— **Laurel Murray** 1099 / Freelance

The BIRT increase hit my business and my family hard this year, especially given the estimated tax requirement for 2027. I made it work but many other business owners in this city cannot and there's no excuse for the city not to find a solution.

— **Caroline Wallinger** Business Consulting

I started dog walking/pet sitting a few years ago because the job market was (and still is) bleak and I could apply what skills I did have to freelancing here in the city to survive. My "business" is just me—I do this to put food on the table, to make sure I can keep shelter. My AGI is about \$30,000 and I'm expected to pay nearly \$4,000 to the city in just BIRT taxes, on top of the thousands in other taxes I have to pay? While food and shelter are increasingly expensive and I've cut my food intake due to not being able to afford to feed myself properly? On top of which, we already have plenty of tax money—it's just a lot of it is going to PPD, which is unnecessary.

— **Juliana Flint** 1099 / Freelance

I have a very small business and high taxes really cut into my small profit margin.

— **Stefanie Kroll** 1099 / Freelance

I am an independent contractor and already carry many burdens. I don't have paid time off, vacations, retirement accounts, or company provided health care. This BIRT tax is an additional expense that keeps me financially in the red.

— **George Phillips** Process Server

My taxes went up more than \$7k while corporations get tax breaks.

— **Joy Manning** 1099 / Freelance

I have lived in Philadelphia for most of the last 26 years and have owned property in the city since 2003. I started my solo consulting practice almost 5 years ago. This year was my first year paying BIRT, which almost tripled my city earnings tax payments over the prior year. I see my taxes go up every year on everything, and yet, little to no improvement in City services or quality of life. Enough is enough. Stop trying to balance this city's budget on the backs of its workers and small businesses and tax the developers, corporations, and wealthy more!

— **Michele Walls** Business Consulting

I am a brand new business owner and these kinds of taxes bury me! Adding these kinds of taxes kills new small businesses and work that could bring new money and life to the city.

— **Stefanie Lau** Business Consulting

I've lived and worked in Philadelphia since 2002, and I need to be able to afford to run my business here. I'm an executive coach, and the repeal of the tax exemptions has been beyond brutal, making me look into alternative locations to move my whole family to. I don't want to leave, but I may not be able to afford to stay if City Council doesn't find a way to mitigate this tax mess.

— **Veronica Scarpellino** *Business Consulting*

I am a new business owner—it is just me and I advise and assist nonprofits on their strategy and program development. Given the nature of my work, I do not make a lot of money doing this and this tax has made my finances even more challenging. Please consider returning the \$100,000 BIRT exemption.

— **Katherine** *Business Consulting*

My business is 10 years old and this seems like the highest tax bill received to date despite it not being a particularly profitable year.

— **Corey Acri** *IT & Tech Support*

I've run my business for 15 years and BIRT be crazy.

— **Chris Alfano** *IT & Tech Support*

Now more than ever we need policies that support individual workers and small business owners. They are the lifeblood of our neighborhoods and our local economy. Saving the city money while also extending relief to entrepreneurs in our local area is a no-brainer.

— **Sean Holmes** *IT & Tech Support*

I work for several vibrant and key small businesses and watch them struggle with city taxes. Everyone pays their fair share gladly. But it's hurtful to have to pay 100% of the next year up front. Also, the exemption helps offset the fact that city income is taxed very high.

— **Dawn Bradley** *Administration*

I run a business here and while we make over the threshold anyway, taxing on gross receipts is an absurd policy. Remove the rampant grift and fraud in the system before you come for my livelihood.

— **Stephen Cassano** *Marketing & PR*

I don't make enough money to pay more to the city than the wage tax.

— **Robert Salvin** *Legal*

I've run a business for over 10 years and the tax is killing me.

— **Jovida Benson** *Finance*

BIRT is a terrible model. It incentivizes people to move their businesses outside of the city and then penalizes those who want to keep their business here in Philly.

— **Ryan Callahan** *Event Planning*

Housing & Real Estate (15 signers)

My family has been housing providers in the city for over 20 years providing safe and affordable housing.

— **Devi** *Housing*

My family has been housing providers in the city for over 20 years providing safe and affordable housing.

— **Mayur Jadeja** *Housing*

My family has been housing providers in the city for over 20 years providing safe and affordable housing.

— **Kaushal Jadeja** *Housing*

I am a lifelong Philadelphia resident and small business owner. With the removal of the BIRT tax exemption and the U&O tax exemption Philadelphia has laid a huge double tax burden on small businesses in the same year. It is so bad that I am contemplating moving out of the city and selling my properties. Small businesses are what help to drive the uniqueness and diversity of the city. Exempting sole proprietorships from BIRT tax will help to maintain this diversity which makes Philadelphia a great place to live.

— **Ian Kerr** *Real Estate*

We have members who are small mom and pops in this industry who are going to get affected by this very drastically, so we request to protect the people who make Philadelphia work.

— **Priya** *Real Estate*

I've been a landlord for 42 years in Philadelphia. I'm a sole proprietor and I work hard to give my tenants a decent place to live. I need the BIRT exception.

— **Katherine DeAngelis** *Real Estate*

I have run my small business for 20 years. The new BIRT taxes are further threatening my small business with a big jump in expenses. It is already barely making it with all the regulations and fees.

— **Deborah Hoskins** *Real Estate*

I have run my small business for 20 years. The new BIRT taxes are further pressuring my sustainability as a business.

— **Steve Hoskins** *Real Estate*

I barely make enough as it is to pay my bills and survive, so paying an additional and unexpected few thousand dollars in BIRT and NPT taxes really hurt me. Completely wiped out any savings I had and now I'm scared for any emergencies that pop up.

— **Vered Gordon** *Real Estate*

I got slapped with a huge unexpected tax bill which puts projected house projects on hold. So I cannot hire other small business owners because of this tax.

— **Patrick Hatfield** *Real Estate*

Business taxes are extraordinarily high in Philadelphia. Higher than most cities with the burden largely levied on small businesses. The structure is holding the entire city back. Small businesses are especially the foundation of Philadelphia's vibe and attraction.

— **Jeanne Whipple** *Real Estate*

The fact that sole proprietors have been subject to the BIRT has been a bone of contention for me for years. We are essentially our own employees and should be taxed at the same rate as any normal employee: the city wage tax based on our net income from the business. The BIRT should be reserved for businesses with more than 1 (one) employee!

— **Eric Moore** *Real Estate*

The change has significant impact on my income.

— **Joshua Zissman** *Real Estate*

I'm an independent contractor directly affected by this law.

— **Phyllis Attisano** *Real Estate*

I've been a full-time licensed real estate Agent & landlord here since 1984.

— **Neil Kugelman** *Real Estate*

Health & Wellness (17 signers)

I've been doing this 15 years. It's astronomical!

— **Stephanie Marsh** *Pet Care & Dog Walking*

This is my newest business but I also own another business unrelated; this is affecting both.

— **Stephanie Ngo** *Salon*

We have been hit hard in the past 6 years from Covid closures, Hurricane Ida, rising economic costs, and now being unfairly taxed. We want to be able to pay our employees and ourselves a livable wage sustainably, and give back to the citizens of Philadelphia.

— **Tracey Taulbee** *Personal Training & Fitness*

I work with many local creators and makers who are directly affected by this tax.

— **Robert Perry** *Restaurant & Hospitality*

The BIRT was on the verge of being phased out and the removal of the \$100k exclusion for small businesses is a slap in the face. The removal tells small businesses that the City of Philadelphia is not small business friendly.

— **Holly Heenan** *Retail*

I started my business 25 years ago.

— **Bob Pierson** *Retail Food*

The attack on small businesses is predatory and disgusting. Small businesses work tirelessly around the clock to make a living and provide for themselves and their community while facing countless fees just to be able to operate. This nonsense cuts into their bottom line and impacts what they are able to provide. 3% taken from every card transaction, 8% sales tax on each sale. This is not the group of businesses that needs 5% taken from them. Taking \$5,000 from someone who makes \$100,000 will result in raised prices making locally grown and created food less accessible to the community.

— **Jeanette** *Farmers' Market*

I own Natty Contrera Artistry and Mango Marketing Co. I owe twice as much as I did last year and made less money. This is hurting small businesses that want to help Philadelphia grow.

— **Natalie Contrera** *Hair & Beauty*

I've run my business in Philly for over 17 years. The BIRT tax is a major deterrent to being a business in the city. Small businesses like mine are the backbone of our local economy and staples of our communities. This tax is an enormous financial burden on businesses that have proven their grit, determination, and dedication to our communities. We add to the value of living in Philadelphia and should be treated with respect. This tax will make it difficult for these staples within neighborhoods to remain. Remove gross profit tax from businesses with incomes under \$100,000!

— **Jennifer Corbin** *Healthcare*

4-year-old business helping to revitalize Port Richmond. Trying to support my family and my children, and my employees.

— **Madison Hirsch** *Jewelry*

I've been in this industry in Philadelphia 13 years, and opened my shop 4 years ago. It's getting harder and harder to be an independent barber or small business owner in this city.

— **Vincent Crapello** *Barbering & Hair Care*

The BIRT exemption helped over 65,000 businesses invest more into their communities and businesses. Small businesses and artisans deserve a chance to thrive.

— **Cat W** *Alterations & Tailoring*

Just started my business.

— **Crystal St. Fort** *Beauty*

I can barely afford to keep the doors open as is. I have 20 employees depending on me to put food on their tables.

— **Katherine Wade** *Pet Care & Dog Walking*

Taxes are really high for making very little.

— **Ross MacKinnon** *Health*

Killing me with more taxes and less opportunity.

— **Melissa Morales** *Retail*

I've had my pet sitting business since 2010. It's just me, I do not make 6 figures. These taxes are brutal for the "little guys" who have a small business. I'm just trying to live.

— **Debbie Drubin** *Pet Sitter*

Small Business Owners (39 signers)

This gives an additional reason to leave the city.

— **Eli Strasberg**

I have a small therapy business that is less than two years old. I make such little income yearly and paid so much in taxes this year. I do not know how this can be sustainable for my business moving forward with all of the expenses I already have.

— **Jennifer**

The rapid, forced imposition of these newest taxes is what makes this so unbearable. 1% over 5-6-7 years is manageable, predictable, foreseeable. Having a 5.7% tax is debilitating. And for it to be taxed on gross receipts and not net income is honestly asinine and will drive small businesses out of the county. There was no way to prepare, no way to save, no way to see this coming. We were uninformed and taken advantage of as small businesses. We don't individually have much leverage. But we must all collaborate to create a stop to this—to create a better plan to raise revenue for the city while not robbing small businesses.

— **Madeleine Heimer** *Landscaping & Lawn Care*

I am a contractor for the early intervention program in Philadelphia. This tax has made it difficult for me to continue to serve our city's students.

— **Jenna Butler**

Protect small local business from debilitating and unfair taxation.

— **Dominic Aquilino**

I cannot afford this tax and neither can any other freelancer in this city!

— **Kim Kelly**

I am a small business and this year's tax bill (BIRT) really hurt and negatively affected my livelihood.

— **Ruth Scott Blackson**

This is an unfair tax on sole self employed who every day "eat what they kill." Big corps get a better deal.

— **Lisa A Barretta**

The BIRT has made me question my community based small business and whether I can keep it going.

— **Petra Rebecca Artz**

Because our survival is seriously being threatened!

— **Tracey Olkus**

I am still developing my practice and growing my business. The BIRT tax was 3x what I paid the state this year. Times are already tough economically and this felt like a punch in the stomach.

— **Benjamin R Tavares**

As a small business, this tax really hurts especially with paying the estimated tax in advance. The city is showing that it's not interested in helping smaller businesses grow.

— **Jay Soda**

My husband is an independent contractor, so this change affects our family directly. As an environmental writer and educator, he is responsible for helping to protect our vital natural resources. In addition, I have worked independently as a theatre artist in the past and likely will again, which means this change could affect both of us in the future, further impacting our tax liability and straining our family's finances.

— **Gwen Naglak**

I relocated my business after a decade in Philadelphia, largely because of the burden of both the high taxes, but also the huge administrative burden of the returns, and the difficulty in dealing with the city departments. I am now hiring an employee in Philadelphia, and nearly rethought a truly excellent hire because the city taxes and the administrative burden are so high. It's a notoriously unfriendly city for small businesses like mine, and I really hope the city takes serious steps to remedy the changes to BIRT. They are unfair and unsustainable.

— **Katharine Strathmann**

I am a sole proprietor and new home owner in Philadelphia. I have been operating as a sole proprietor for the past 5 years. Previously, I owed approximately \$20 annually for BIRT. This year, I owed nearly \$9,000. That is more than I owed the state of Pennsylvania. This is unsustainable.

— **Rachele Fortier**

Taking more money from the working class is not the way to increase city revenues and you know it.

— **Timaree L Schmit**

This affects all of us average Joe blokes.

— **Darien Blackmon Jr** *Industry Business*

Support small businesses.

— **JOSHUA M VALOCCHI** *Vinyl Record Sales (Online)*

I run a business here.

— **Katerina**

The new BIRT bill is bad for my biz, bad for me, bad for the city. Please fix this injustice.

— **Anne Gemmell**

Freelancers shouldn't have to pay a higher tax rate than regular corporate employees. Also, the BIRT requirement that the next year's tax has to be paid entirely before the money has even been earned is just crazy. Most freelancers don't have the money upfront and cannot predict how much they will make.

— **Patrick Fitzsimmons**

We have been running our real estate business since 2000. We have been legal, good landlords and have kept some tenants for years. Our first tenant raised her son at our property from the time he was 5 years old until he graduated high school. We offer our tenants clean, solid houses. Please keep the real estate taxes in line so we can continue to offer reasonable rents.

— **Margaret Barnes-DelColle**

I'm still a newer business owner. This tax makes it extremely difficult to keep a standard living while continuing to help my clients. Many of us are doing meaningful work, and this tax is setting us back.

— **Caroline O'Brien**

I am a gig worker and opened a business 2.5 years ago. I am in the growing stages of getting a business off the ground. I also have a child in daycare and I was not anticipating this high of tax payments to be made. This surprise increase has made it so that I am unable to pay my credit card bills, which carry hefty late fees. I applied for the free tax prep offered through the city only to have a disorganized experience that ultimately led me to hire my own accountant.

— **Patricia Dominguez**

The BIRT tax is a gross way to repay folks for creating small businesses in the city of Philadelphia. I shouldn't have to consider leaving Philadelphia to avoid being crushed with taxes as someone who works for and by myself.

— **Samantha Swartz**

I started my business in January 2020. I've weathered the pandemic and continued to evolve my business to meet the changing needs of my clients and customers. However, when we tax smaller businesses more than larger businesses, as a city we're reducing the incentives to be nimble and innovative.

— **Kara Lindstrom**

I would prefer to not move my business outside of Philadelphia, but I will have to if BIRT continues.

— **Sam Sperling**

I've owned my business in Philadelphia for several years, and having to pay even more taxes in an already heavily taxed city is a huge burden on my business. Small businesses and gig workers in Philadelphia don't deserve to be slapped with a tax higher than corporations when we keep the city's economy alive and thriving.

— **Cindy Lozito**

Because this is affecting all of us.

— **Katherine Mejia**

To protect myself and my business from unnecessary changes.

— **Miriam Shapiro**

I am just starting to build a business, in the planning stages. And it disheartens me to know how much small businesses will be taxed. There has to be a balance.

— **Amanda Steck**

Small business owner that cannot reasonably afford this new tax. Taxes are so high for small business owners already. This will put us all out of business. I won't be surprised if you see a high number of businesses leaving Philly or shutting down this year.

— **Nicole Saltzer**

I am signing this petition because I am one of the people this impacts. As a self-employed professional and small business owner in Philadelphia, I work hard to create income, serve others, and keep moving forward. Like many independent workers, I do not have the cushion or resources of a large corporation. Every dollar matters. It helps pay for housing, utilities, food, business expenses, and the basic stability needed to keep contributing to this city. This tax change makes it harder for people like me to stay in business and sustain a living. It feels unfair that individuals, sole proprietors, gig workers, and mom-and-pop businesses can end up carrying a heavier tax burden than corporations. I am asking City Council and Council President Johnson to hold a hearing and bring Bill No. 251026 to a vote. Philadelphia should stand with the people who work hard, hustle, serve their communities, and help keep this city alive.

— **Tina Muheim**

Taxes are too high, risking my small business's survival.

— **Walid Baruki**

Small businesses are the backbone of Philadelphia. A common sense tax code has been needed for a long time.

— **Daniela Ascarelli**

We are incurring way too many taxes as of late. Rents are ridiculous. Something needs to change. This isn't NYC or LA. Philadelphia needs to encourage people to want to live here and own businesses, not chase them away. We need something to encourage people to move here, and lower taxes can do that.

— **Michelle Marchiano**

I'm a disabled person supporting disabled people. Small businesses make our communities work!

— **Mattia Mauree**

This affected my business on a very personal level. I, along with so many other small business owners I know, feel this is a predatory tax law that is not in the best interests of the people of Philadelphia.

— **Rose Flannery Cronin**

The BIRT tax is affecting the small business I work for, and many other friends and acquaintances who work as independent contractors or run their own small business. It's become more difficult for businesses to afford expenses, including payroll, let alone periodic wage raises to employees. Independent contractors struggle enough as it is to find a steady stream of income, now the city is demanding a huge percentage of their net income. It's not just unfair—it's cruel!

— **Emily Mogil** *Skilled Worker*

Tax Professionals (2 signers)

I'm a self-employed artist. And I'm a self-employed tax preparer who prepares taxes for self-employed artists and creative professionals. This year has been heart wrenching for me, as I've had to explain the BIRT changes over and over again to people just scraping by. We all love our city and choose to stay here and work here—but we need a tax structure that will lift us up, not grind us down.

— **Maria Möller** *Tax Preparation*

I'm a business owner of a tax firm and the gig workers are unfairly paying so much tax. I particularly think high school students with summer jobs that receive a 1099 shouldn't be paying BIRT at all.

— **Jessica DeJesus** *Accounting & Bookkeeping*

Supporters & Community (38 signers)

I was an independent contractor for years and it was difficult to pay taxes and all other expenses. I want to stand with my fellow Social Workers who have to pay this unexpected tax.

— **Samantha Ruiz**

I'm signing because many of my neighbors are small business owners with very small margins. Companies like Amazon have already made it so much harder for small businesses to thrive; we should be doing everything we can to support small business owners in Philly. Small business owners are actually part of our communities—the money they earn stays in our community. This helps everyone! If you want to raise taxes, raise them on Amazon, Walmart, Target, CVS, etc.

— **Kristen Scalise**

Small businesses are a large part of what makes this city special and we need to stop making it so hard for them to survive before we're left with nothing but chains.

— **Brad Wilhelm**

I support Philly's Mom and Pop Business Owners — the gig economy.

— **Larry Davis**

To support a friend working in Philadelphia.

— **Juliane Stopka**

Concern that this tax will drive small businesses out of the city, lowering tax revenue and making it harder for people to find needed services.

— **Dominic Aquilino**

My husband is an independent contractor so this extreme tax hike affects me as well. He's been doing this for over 10 years and wants to continue doing so, but if we can't move outside the city this year to avoid this drastic increase, we're done for and he's out of work.

— **Sara Sierschula**

I respect the work it takes to have a small business. I do not approve of this additional burden.

— **Carmen Mulraney**

So many small businesses are closing. Every third storefront in Philly is closed and depressed. Signing this to put an end to it!

— **SARAH Froberg**

Philly can do better for its citizens and small business owners.

— **Emily Barriball**

I don't want Philly punishing creatives!

— **Brendan Bense**

This affects my friends and neighbors. I love all the small independent businesses and would hate to lose them.

— **Zoey Geary**

I've been doing tax prep for artists for about 20 years, and I've seen many changes to our local tax code—some good (the \$100k exemption for BIRT, getting rid of the one-time cost for the commercial activity license), some bad (the terrible portal, getting rid of the \$100k exemption). I'm worried these new BIRT rules will drive artists out of the city I love. For low income artists running their art practice as a small business, the BIRT is so burdensome.

— **Amy Smith**

My wife is a small business owner and due to the BIRT we will have to relocate our family.

— **James Farrell**

I was an independent artist and non-profit worker for 15 years in Philadelphia and know many who presently are—freelance and independent workers are the backbone of Philly and deserve essential support, not higher taxes.

— **Jill Harrison**

No one should have to fear how much tax increases will affect their daily lives.

— **Alicia Gonzalez**

My wife runs her own small, solo private therapy practice and I am currently disabled. The extra tax burden from this BIRT disaster makes an already stressful life that much more unbearable.

— **Michael Mikulla**

I have friends who are now financially devastated by losing the exemption. Tax the rich! There's no reason this should apply to people that are struggling.

— **Timothy Benoit**

I'm lucky enough to have a W2 paycheck right now, but I'm 50 years old and have worked most of my career on 1099s. This is not just about small business owners or tradespeople with contracting businesses. Lots of people who earn money as 1099 workers are scraping by on gigs; lots of them have a regular job where their company pays them on a 1099 basis (whether it's legal or not). I never owned a business, but I've been a freelancer for most of my life. The way this city taxes regular working people is absolutely terrible, and it got worse last year. The old \$100k exemption was a small step toward fairness, but it wasn't enough. I understand that the legalities of this are tricky. This bill is not enough either, but it seems like a good start.

— **David Scholnick**

Small businesses are a vital part of the city and will be even more important to the city's future than before with the rise of AI. We need to relieve the pain, not add to it.

— **Vince Quinn**

I'm signing because everyone deserves a fair chance to survive in this already messed up economy.

— **Marcy A Alarcon**

As a former freelancer in Philadelphia I know how hard this city makes it to be an independent contractor.

— **David Dritsas**

I'm signing this petition because the cost of living in Philadelphia continues to rise while wages are not keeping up, and it feels like that reality is being ignored. Even after working hard to increase my income, I still feel like I'm back at square one financially. The constant financial pressures and added costs in this city make it harder and harder to actually get ahead. If I'm feeling this strain while earning above the average household income, I can only imagine how difficult it is for those making significantly less—especially individuals who rely on gig work or self-employment to survive. Removing the BIRT exemption only adds another layer of financial pressure to people who are already doing everything they can to make ends meet. I don't want to see families struggling to afford basic necessities like housing, food, and childcare. Philadelphia should be a city where hard work leads to stability, not where people are taxed further into financial stress.

— **Cierra Cole**

For all of those affected.

— **Tara Adams**

It's an important issue that deserves attention.

— **Debra Holloway**

Supporting small businesses in my town of Fishtown, Philadelphia.

— **Reyno Bueno**

I'm disabled and unable to sustain full time work—starting my own business is my only option to pay my bills. I shouldn't be paying at this rate while major businesses skirt taxes through incentive programs and loopholes. Small business entrepreneurship can help Philly thrive and attract bigger businesses to contribute more.

— **Meridith Burkus**

As a native of Philadelphia we love our one-on-one shops that are run by smaller business owners—it builds community. Why would you tax the small business as much as you tax the big business that can easily pay this amount? It's not supportive.

— **Brandi Lewis-Anderson**

To support friends and the arts of independent contractors.

— **Natalie Suresch**

Small businesses are what bring character to the city. We need to prioritize helping them succeed.

— **Sarah Kittrell**

In support of regular Philadelphia citizens trying to make a living by having a small business.

— **Kathy Caponigro**

I am concerned about my local economy! Some of my favorite places are small businesses, and some of my favorite people are independent contractors or own their own small business. We need policy changes and tax reform!

— **Kelly Flynn**

I'm very concerned about the impact BIRT is going to have on small businesses throughout the city and in my community. Philadelphia is a city that thrives on small businesses and we should be supporting them, not harming them. BIRT will cause unnecessary hardship for so many. There is a better way. City Council needs to work with them to do this.

— **Beth Gargiulo**

I'm an employee at the Navy Yard and started my own business. I believe the city's budget and tax codes do not make sense and require major improvements.

— **Crystal Peton**

BIRT exemption should exist for those making under \$40k.

— **Leslie Sullivan**

Many of my friends that own small businesses are struggling. I am concerned that businesses I support are going to go out of business this year!

— **Chris Herrman**

My husband has a small business in the city—our family was impacted by this change this year.

— **Meredith Weber**

My husband runs a small business and this hit us hard. We had to use a large part of our savings to cover the costs especially since we were forced to prepay 2027.

— **Melissa Rivera**